successfully hide the real economic situation and widespread corruption up until autumn 2006. That year a secretly recorded closed-door discussion by Gyurcsany went on air in which the Prime Minister bluntly admitted that the government had been lying to the public for some time and had also not done anything right in the same period.

This brought Orbán back to power in the April 2010 elections in which Fidesz alone gained a two-thirds majority, also thanks to the media empire that his business acolytes had managed to build in the meantime. The landslide victory was followed, in 2011, by hasty amendments of the constitution and a series of laws, and by swift changes in various government-controlled boards, councils etc., thus consolidating power across public institutions. Orbán embarked on a campaign to rein in various institutions outside the narrow frame of government – 'on a Gramscian programme of social transformation',[141] following the school of thought of the Italian Marxist Gramsci who saw power residing in cultural institutions. Indeed, as we shall see, this has not been a simple battle for power and money only, but also for the souls of Hungarians – the so-called culture wars. The previous dominance of the political left was thus replaced by an equally complete domination of the Orbán-led right. According to Lendvai, it was all about mere will to power, only superficially hidden under a care for traditional values, undoubtedly important to a large part of the Hungarian electorate. Apart from the appeal of referring to Christian values, the trauma of Trianon (the loss of territory after World War I according to the Treaty of Trianon) played a key part in gaining such strong support:[142] 'No Hungarian reacts with indifference when it comes to the architectural gems and memorials, the graves of mighty kings and the birth houses of great poets, in the old Hungarian towns in Transylvania (Romania), 'Upper Hungary' (Slovakia) and Vojvodina (Serbia),' writes Lendvai.[143] Orbán has continued to play on 'two predominant elements of Hungarian self-image – the victim myth and the will to survive'.[144]

This complete domination of Fidesz loyalists eventually opened the door to widespread corruption, which Lendvai argues can no longer be compared to the corruption of left-wing governments in the 2002-2010 period (to which the author is by no means lenient). It also led to controversial relations between Hungary on the one hand, and China and Russia on the other, as also evident again years later during the Russian aggression in